



Report Date: March 18, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

[Submit comments to the Board](#)

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Business Services
SUBJECT: Bard on the Beach - Burrard Civic Marina Temporary Storage Facility - Lease of Space

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Park Board approve a request by Bard on the Beach Shakespeare Festival for the lease of space at Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for use as a temporary storage facility, including the installation of a Quonset tent structure, as outlined in this report;
- B. THAT the Vancouver Park Board authorize staff to negotiate, to the satisfaction of the Park Board's General Manager and the City's Director of Legal Services, and enter into an agreement with Bard on the Beach Shakespeare Festival for the abovementioned initiative for a term of ten (10) years; and
- C. THAT no legal rights or obligations shall arise, and no consents, permissions, or licenses are granted hereby, and none shall arise or be granted hereafter unless and until all contemplated legal documentation has been executed and delivered by all parties.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

Established in 1990, Bard on the Beach ("BOTB" or "Festival") is Western Canada's largest not-for-profit professional Shakespeare Festival. A longstanding Vancouver summertime favourite, the Festival is presented in Vancouver's Vanier Park against a spectacular backdrop of mountains, sea, and sky.

With the Festival's growth and maturity over the past three and a half decades, the ongoing evolution of park use over the same period, and significant post-pandemic cost increases in hosting arts, culture, and event initiatives, a number of issues have emerged which present both financial and operational challenges for BOTB as well as the Park Board. Staff from BOTB and the Park Board have worked collaboratively since 2024 to explore opportunities to address these issues. A quick win opportunity (leaving the Festival's mainstage arches onsite at Vanier Park during the event's off-season) was identified and approved by the Board in October 2024. The purpose of this report is to present a new opportunity involving the lease of space at the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for use as a temporary storage facility, including the installation of a Quonset tent structure, explain the needs and benefits of this initiative, and seek the Board's approval to pursue the opportunity for a period of ten (10) years.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

Per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over parkland use in the City of Vancouver (including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements within parks) and approves the use of all lands under its jurisdiction on such terms as the Park Board may decide.

On June 22, 2020, at an *in camera* meeting (with the decision subsequently made public in a [memo](#) to the Board on March 2, 2023), the Park Board approved a series of Planning Principles as a framework for initiating a collaborative master planning process for Seḥákw/Vanier Park between the Park Board and the xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), Skwxwú7mesh Úxwumixw (Squamish), and səliłwətał (Tsleil-Waututh) peoples (“MST” or “Host Nations”). This work would be undertaken jointly with the City of Vancouver’s Arts, Culture and Community Services department (ACCS). While staff have undertaken initial outreach to the Host Nations, the timeline for undertaking a full planning process and associated public and stakeholder engagement is not currently confirmed; accordingly, the initiative referenced in this report is not expected to have an impact on this longer-term work.

On October 19, 2020, the Park Board approved the [VanPlay Framework](#), as Vancouver’s [Parks and Recreation Services Master Plan](#). VanPlay sets out priorities and provides tools and policies to support the pursuit of equity, connectivity, and access to parks and recreation for all. The Framework provides a succinct method for referencing and implementing VanPlay directions. The Pilot Program referenced in this report aligns and contributes to VanPlay’s directions to “Welcome Everyone” (parks and recreation experiences that improve quality of life) and “Weave the City Together” (parks, nature, recreation and culture integrated into everyday life).

On January 16, 2023, the Board approved the [“Think Big” Revenue Strategy motion](#) to prioritize and enable opportunities for increased commercial revenues. Subsequently, on July 17, 2023, the Board endorsed the Think Big Action Plan as presented in Appendix A in the [“Think Big” Revenue Strategy – Report Back: July 6, 2023](#), and further validated the preliminary revenue-generating opportunities presented in Appendix D, which included enabling seasonal/temporary park attractions/services and activating public spaces.

On October 21, 2024, at a public meeting, the Park Board approved an [application from BOTB for a pilot program](#) enabling the Festival’s mainstage arches to remain on site at Vanier Park during the event’s off-season between November 2024 and March 2025. The Board [subsequently approved the continuation of this pilot program](#) between November 2025 and March 2026, and conditionally in future years, at a public meeting on November 3, 2025.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Overview

Established in 1990, Bard on the Beach is Western Canada’s largest not-for-profit professional Shakespeare Festival. A longstanding Vancouver summertime favourite, the Festival is presented in Vancouver’s Vanier Park against a spectacular backdrop of mountains, sea, and sky, and offers Shakespeare plays, related dramas, and special events in two modern performance tents from June through September. The Festival is known for its signature blend of high-quality artistic programming and a welcoming, informal experience for local residents and visitors from around the world.

On-Going Issues/Market Pressures

With the Festival's growth and maturity over the past three and a half decades, the changing nature of park use over the same period, and the significant post-pandemic cost increases in arts, culture and event hosting, several challenges have emerged which present financial and operational pressures and impacts for BOTB, park users, and the Park Board.

Collaborative Planning & Pilot Program

Staff from BOTB and the Park Board have been working collaboratively since 2024 to identify opportunities to address or reduce the impact of these challenges for the mutual benefit of the Festival, park users, and the Park Board. In particular, the financial and logistical realities of BOTB's signature infrastructure have become increasingly challenging and threaten the Festival's financial and programmatic sustainability. Through these discussions, a quick win pilot program opportunity was identified in late 2024 which involved leaving the Festival's mainstage arches onsite at Vanier Park during the event's off-season between mid-November and mid-March. The pilot program was successfully implemented and recently renewed for future years.

New Opportunity

Through on-going discussions between BOTB and Park Board staff, a second opportunity has been identified with potential to provide meaningful expense and logistical relief for BOTB, while transferring no costs to the Park Board, protecting existing Park Board revenue streams, and minimizing disruptions to marina operations. This new opportunity involves supporting BOTB by leasing space to the Festival at the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for use as a temporary storage facility.

DISCUSSION**Event Proposal**

Given the positive outcomes of the pilot program and the Park Board's interest in supporting a core partner and iconic Vancouver arts and culture institution, the Festival organizers are seeking the Board's approval to lease approximately 20,000 square feet of space in the Burrard Civic Marina land storage area for use as a temporary storage facility, including the installation of a 7,000 square foot Quonset fabric tent structure (see Appendix A). This storage facility would be fenced and operated independently from the marina by BOTB.

The amount of space being requested is located within an existing Park Board commercial location and is slightly smaller than the area approved by the Board for use as special event site in 2021/2022. It's estimated that the storage facility would occupy roughly 17% of the marina's land storage lot, leaving the remainder of the site available for traditional marina land operations. Park Board staff have determined that the space required for the Festival storage facility can be made available largely through lot realignment to improve overall storage lot efficiency (paid for by BOTB); non-renewal of some transitory/short-term boat storage requests may also be required (BOTB will reimburse the Park Board for any potential lost revenue).

To rationalize and recover the investment needed to set up the storage facility, a 10-year agreement will be required by BOTB for this initiative.

Why is this Needed

BOTB re-assembles its festival site annually starting in mid-March, opening to the public in early June, running until late September, and then dismantling and storing equipment and infrastructure from mid-November through the winter, until mid-March when re-assembly begins once again. Currently, the Festival leases approximately 15,000 square feet of warehouse space in Richmond and another 5,000 square feet in Surrey.

With its warehouse lease in Richmond ending in December 2026, for site re-development, BOTB staff have been exploring ways to replace this lost storage space under very challenging market conditions (current market warehouse lease rates far exceed the Festival's available resources/capacity).

The opportunity to lease space in the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for a temporary storage facility, including a Quonset structure (7,000 square foot fabric roofed tent; see Appendix B), for a temporary year-round storage facility represents a very important component of a larger package of solutions needed to address BOTB's financial pressures. Under this proposal, BOTB would pay for all expenses related to setting up the storage area and any necessary changes to the marina land storage parking lot, to create a fully separate and secure storage area. If approved by the Board, BOTB would migrate equipment and materials that don't require climate control during set-up this spring to the Quonset tent and the storage facility. As part of the arrangement with the marina, BOTB would also cover the cost of surface repair and line-painting for the full marina parking lot.

Program Benefits

The cost associated with leasing the outdoor parking lot space at Burrard Civic Marina is significantly less than the comparable cost for warehouse space, thereby enabling BOTB to realize important storage cost savings. For the Park Board, there would be no expenses or negative impacts to existing revenue streams related to this program. If approved, the Festival expects to store roughly half of the equipment currently kept in their Richmond warehouse within the Quonset structure and all of the materials from the storage facility in Surrey, within the proposed fenced compound at the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot. BOTB will still need to acquire approximately 8,000 square feet of temperature-controlled warehouse space elsewhere to store the remainder of their festival equipment and infrastructure.

This potential collaboration and partnership with the Park Board would help Bard navigate the challenging transition to a more efficient storage model for the next decade. In addition, storing this equipment and infrastructure at the marina will provide logistical efficiencies and significantly reduce transportation costs, environmental impacts, and neighbourhood impacts (by eliminating roughly 40 fully loaded semi-trailers trips annually to/from BOTB's Vanier Park location from Surrey or Richmond, as well as numerous trips with a 5-ton transport vehicle).

For the Park Board, the most significant and valuable benefit from this proposal lies in supporting the financial restructuring of an important and long-term tenant to ensure their future financial health and viability, thus protecting Park Board revenue streams derived from BOTB's other operations and activities at Vanier Park. This proposal also has the potential to provide Park Board marina staff with administrative efficiencies.

The Festival is committed to being stable and collaborative partners and will work closely with Park Board staff to ensure the ongoing stewardship of this valued municipal location.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

Subject to Board approval, Park Board staff will work with Festival organizers to finalize the financial terms and conditions of this initiative in a manner consistent with Park Board's Fees & Charges framework and generally accepted market practices. All expenses related to the delivery and execution of this program will be borne by BOTB; accordingly, there will be no costs to the Park Board related to this initiative and revenues currently generated by the Park Board in this space will be fully maintained and protected.

Revenues generated by this initiative will continue to flow to marina operations and be used to support marina activities as well as Park Board budget priorities.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

The storage program is considered to be low risk given it will utilize an existing and previously used commercial space (total area required is slightly smaller than the area set aside to host a special event initiative in 2021/2022), will have minimal impact on marina operations, and will protect/retain Park Board revenue streams needed to meet budgetary requirements through the proposed 10-year term of the agreement.

Marina patrons have been notified of this initiative. Staff anticipate some potential for feedback and comment by a small number of marina users but are confident any identified issues can be mitigated through appropriate strategies and actions.

It is anticipated that the agreement between BOTB and the Park Board will have an exit clause to ensure flexibility should alternate needs arise in the future for the space contemplated by this initiative.

This proposal and program is mutually independent and not linked to other initiatives or agreements between BOTB and the Park Board, including the abovementioned pilot program, or any future initiatives contemplated between the two organizations within Vanier Park.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

Bard on the Beach is Western Canada's largest not-for-profit, professional Shakespeare Festival. Faced with emerging financial and operational pressures, staff from both organizations are engaging collaboratively to identify opportunities to enable Festival cost savings and preserve Park Board revenue streams.

After a successful pilot program involving the leaving of festival infrastructure on-site at Vanier Park during the off-season, a new opportunity has been identified to support the Festival by leasing space in the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for use as a storage facility. Park Board staff have carefully reviewed the various considerations of this program and are confident that this initiative can be executed successfully and as intended. Accordingly, staff recommend that the Board approve the recommendations as outlined in this report.

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APPENDIX A

LOCATION & SITE PLAN OF STORAGE AREA



Figure 1: Location and Site Plan of Storage Area

APPENDIX B

AERIAL VIEW OF STORAGE AREA & QUONSET TENT

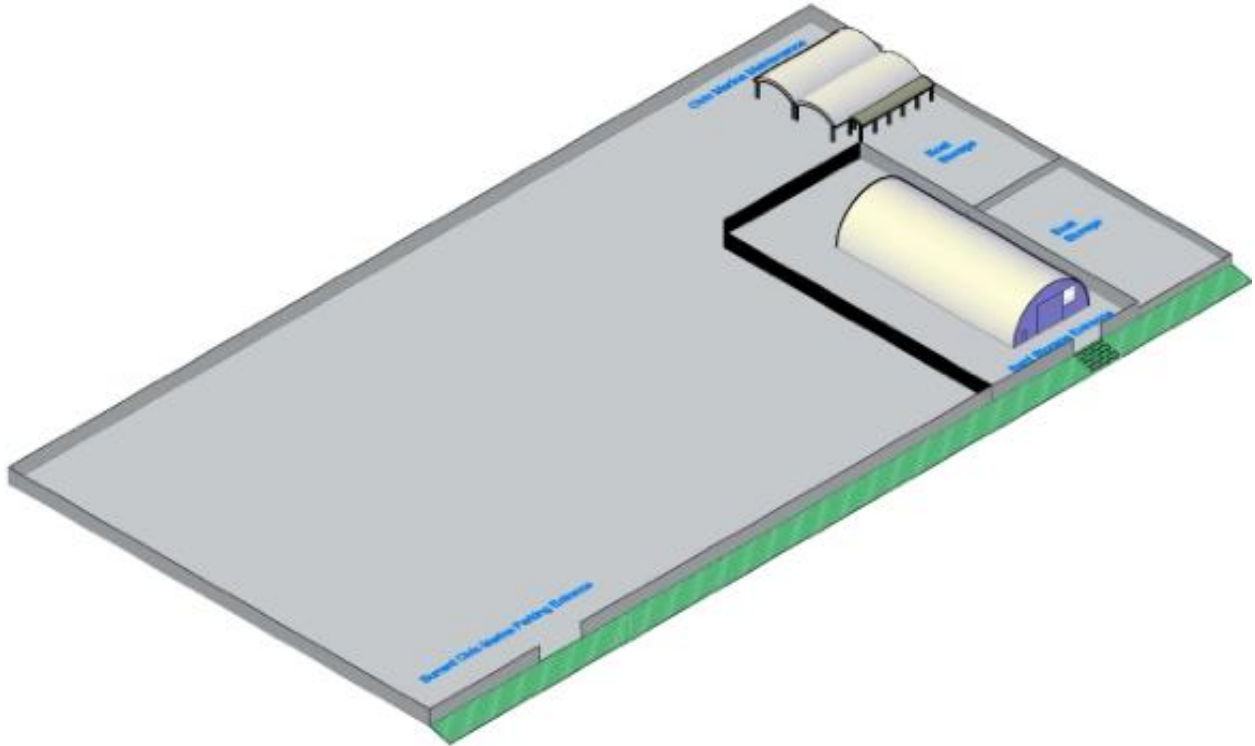


Figure 2: *Rendering of Aerial View of the Storage Area and Quonset Tent.*